



In a performance, light is not just illumination, it is interpretation

ARTS PAGE 3



In his new book, Frank Dikötter sets the record straight on China's ruling party

BOOKS PAGE 4

CHANDIGARH | 29 MARCH 2026



The soaring valuations of RCB and RR signal the IPL's hyper-commercial growth and arrival at the high table of global sport. Can it sustain cricket's essential spirit and integrity while meeting the expectations of investors?



The IPL now stands at a critical juncture. The decisions made in this phase will determine whether it remains a benchmark for others to follow, or becomes a case study in excess

SHISHIR HATTANGADI

WHEN Lalit Modi conceptualised the Indian Premier League (IPL) in 2008, he was not merely launching a cricket tournament — he was reimagining the sport's economic and cultural architecture.

Until then, cricket had largely been the preserve of national boards, its rhythms shaped by bilateral series and tournaments, its revenues tied to gate receipts and traditional broadcast deals. The IPL disrupted that order in one decisive stroke. It fused cricket with entertainment, introduced franchise ownership into a board-dominated ecosystem, and aligned the sport with the language of global capital.

Nearly two decades later, the consequences of that disruption are fully visible. The soaring valuations of franchises such as Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) and the proposed sale of Rajasthan Royals (RR) are not isolated financial events. They signal the IPL's arrival at the high table of global sport — alongside leagues where ownership is fluid, capital is borderless, and teams are valued as long-term assets rather than merely competitive units.

Modi drew inspiration from American leagues such as the National Basketball Association and the National Football League, where privately-owned franchises operate within a centrally-governed system designed to maximise commercial efficiency. Translating that model into cricket — a sport deeply rooted in national identity and public administration — was a leap of imagination.

The introduction of city-based teams, player auctions, salary caps, and revenue-sharing mechanisms created a closed-loop ecosystem that could sustain itself commercially while retaining competitive balance.

In its early years, the IPL's ownership mix reflected both ambition and spectacle. Industrialists, film stars, and corporate houses came together not just to invest, but to build brands. Teams were not merely cricketing entities; they became extensions of identity and aspiration. Jerseys turned into fashion statements, fan bases into communities, and match days into events that transcended sport. This fusion of cricket and culture laid the foundation for the league's explosive growth.

Today, IPL franchises are among the most valuable sporting properties outside North America. The rise in valuation is underpinned by a combination of structural strengths. Chief among them is the league's media ecosystem. Broadcast rights — across television and digital platforms — have delivered unprecedented revenues, creating predictable income streams that investors can model and trust. The IPL's reach, amplified by India's vast population and global diaspora, ensures that it commands one of the largest audiences in sport.

Commercial integration has further strengthened the model. Sponsorships, licensing deals, and brand partnerships have turned franchises into multi-revenue businesses. The limited number of teams has created scarcity value, driving demand among investors. In this context, franchise ownership is no longer a vanity investment; it is a strategic asset class, comparable in many ways to stakes in elite football clubs or American sports franchises.

The proposed sale of Rajasthan Royals, therefore, is more than a transaction. It reflects the emergence of the IPL as a marketplace for ownership, where valuations are tested, negotiated, and reset. The trajectory of the English Premier League offers a useful parallel. Over time, English football clubs have attracted global investors, from private equity firms to sovereign wealth funds, leading to frequent ownership changes and dramatic valuation increases. Clubs such as Manchester United and Chelsea FC have become symbols of this evolution.

The IPL is following a similar path, albeit at remarkable speed. What took the EPL decades has unfolded in less than 20 years in India. This acceleration is a reflection of the country's media boom, its digital penetration, and the scale of its consumer market.

Yet, embedded within this success story are emerging fault lines that merit closer scrutiny.

At the heart of the concern lies valuation itself. As franchise prices climb into stratospheric territory, expectations inevitably rise alongside them. Investors entering at high valuations require commensurate returns, and that pressure can begin to influence decision-making.

Cricket, a sport traditionally defined by patience and nuance, risks being reshaped by the demands of a hyper-commercial environment. When financial imperatives begin to dictate sporting choices — whether in sched-



Royal Challengers Bengaluru players celebrate after winning the Indian Premier League in 2025.

RCB
SOLD FOR
₹16,660
CRORE

ing, rule changes, or player utilisation — the balance between sport and business becomes precarious.

This is not a theoretical concern. History across global sport shows that rapid financial escalation often brings with it a shift in priorities. The question is whether the IPL can sustain its sporting integrity while meeting the expectations of its investors.

A second challenge arises from imitation. The IPL's success has inspired a proliferation of franchise-based T20 leagues around the world — from Australia's Big Bash to South Africa's SA20, and emerging competitions in the UAE and the United States. The ambition to replicate the IPL model is understandable; it promises visibility, investment, and rapid monetisation. However, replication without context carries risk.

The IPL's strength lies not just in its format, but in its ecosystem — India's scale, its broadcast market, its deep talent pool, and its cultural attachment to cricket. These conditions are not easily reproduced elsewhere. An oversupply of leagues could fragment audiences, stretch player availability, and dilute the distinctiveness that makes the IPL special. What is currently a premium product risks becoming one among many.

Closely linked to this is the question of broadcasting — the financial engine that powers the entire structure. Media rights have been the cornerstone of the IPL's growth, but even this engine is subject to limits. As markets mature, growth inevitably slows.

Broadcasters who have committed enormous sums will seek returns that justify their investments. If subscription growth plateaus or advertising revenues stabilise, the ripple effects will be felt across the ecosystem.

A plateau in broadcast revenue is not, in itself, a crisis. But in a system built on expectations of exponential growth, even stability can create pressure. Future rights cycles may not deliver the same dramatic increases, forcing franchises and investors to recalibrate their projections.

Then there is the issue of over-exposure. The cricket calendar is increasingly crowded, with multiple leagues competing for space. This raises concerns not only about player workload, but also about audience fatigue. Scarcity has been central to the IPL's appeal — it has felt like an annual festival, a concentrated burst of high-quality cricket and entertainment. If cricket becomes a year-round carousel of similar formats, that sense of occasion could diminish.

Fan engagement, like any form of attention, is finite. Over-saturation risks eroding the very excitement that has driven the IPL's success.

The implications for cricket's power structure are equally significant. Traditionally, boards — particularly the Board of Control for Cricket in India — have exercised central authority over the sport. The rise of franchise valuations introduces a new class of stakeholders with both financial weight and strategic influence. As investments deepen, so too will the desire for a greater say in governance — whether in scheduling, player availability, or the broader cricket calendar.

This could lead to a gradual rebalancing of power, with private ownership playing a more prominent role in shap-

ing the sport's future. For players, this shift presents both opportunity and complexity. The IPL has already transformed player economics, offering financial security and global exposure. As franchise leagues expand, players may increasingly weigh the demands of international cricket against the opportunities of league participation.

This tension between club and country is not new — it has long been a feature of football — but it is relatively novel in cricket. How it is managed will have profound implications for the sport's identity.

Beyond cricket, the IPL's journey offers important lessons for Indian sport more broadly. It has demonstrated that sport in India can operate as a viable commercial enterprise, attracting investment, building brands, and delivering returns. Leagues such as the Pro Kabaddi League and the Indian Super League owe much to the IPL's template. The introduction of professional governance, data-driven decision-making, and high-performance systems has elevated standards across disciplines.

At the same time, rising valuations have enabled investment in infrastructure — stadiums, academies, and grassroots programmes — creating a pipeline for future talent. In this sense, the IPL has contributed not just to elite sport, but to the broader sporting ecosystem.

And yet, the central question remains unresolved: can the IPL sustain its growth without compromising its essence?

The comparison with the English Premier League is instructive, but not exact. The EPL operates within a global football ecosystem that is both deep and resilient, with multiple revenue streams and a long-established club culture. Cricket's ecosystem is narrower, and more dependent on a few key markets. This makes it more vulnerable to over-expansion and financial shocks.

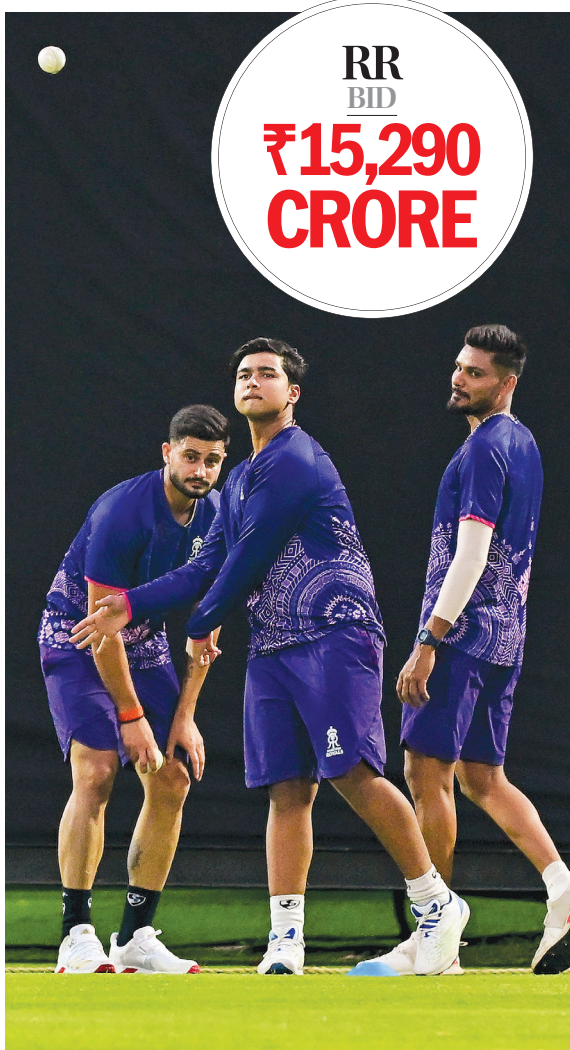
The IPL, in many ways, represents a hybrid model — combining the stability of American franchise systems with the global ambition of European football. This hybridity is its strength, but also its challenge. It must balance competing imperatives: growth and sustainability, commercial success and sporting integrity, global ambition and local identity.

What lies ahead is not simply a continuation of the IPL's upward trajectory, but a more complex phase of consolidation. Expansion into new markets, deeper integration with global leagues, and technological innovation in fan engagement will all play a role. Equally important will be regulatory foresight — ensuring that the league evolves without losing sight of its core values.

The IPL's journey from vision to valuation is, undeniably, one of the most remarkable stories in modern sport. It has redefined cricket, reshaped economics, and positioned India at the centre of the global sporting conversation. But every success carries within it the seeds of its next challenge. The IPL now stands at a critical juncture — not one of survival, but of stewardship. The decisions made in this phase will determine whether it remains a benchmark for others to follow, or becomes a case study in excess.

For cricket, and for Indian sport, the opportunity is immense. So too is the responsibility.

— The writer is a former captain of the Mumbai Ranji Trophy team



Rajasthan Royals players warm up during a practice session ahead of the Indian Premier League T20 matches. PHOTOS: PTI

PLUS AND MINUS OF IT

“It's great news for the sport, for its development and for its popularity. However, this would also allow owners' interference considering the high stakes of money involved. Also, it may hit Test cricket, with such huge popularity of T20 cricket. The sport is always loved by Indian fans, its craze is something unmatched compared to other events, and such high valuations indicate that cricket is grabbing attention worldwide”

Pradeep Magazine, SPORTS JOURNALIST AND AUTHOR

The forgotten wisdom



FOOD TALK
PUSHPESH PANT

EVERY challenge also presents an opportunity. Adversity tests our ingenuity. The war in West Asia has ignited an energy crisis that appears to threaten our food security and imperil economic growth. The interruption in the supplies of LPG, the ubiquitous cooking fuel, and CNG, that has increasingly replaced diesel and petrol in the modes of transportation of essential and perishable goods, has led to menus at home and in restaurants being hastily revised.

As fuel supplies tighten, Indian kitchens confront a moment of change — reviving old practices and embracing smarter, more sustainable ways of cooking and eating



RAITA TO THE RESCUE.



MAKE THE MOST OF INDUCTION COOKER.



REDISCOVERING THE TANDOOR. ISTOCK



FUEL-EFFICIENT ONE-POT KHICHDI.



CHARGRILL THOSE KEBABS AND TIKKAS.

Can we switch from scarce, imported gas to forgotten traditional cooking mediums — charcoal and wood, or renewable innovative sources like solar? Those dwelling in the cities and towns think first of all of electricity. Can induction cookers, microwaves and rice cookers help us tide over the difficult days? Those residing in the countryside may be tempted to fall back on brushwood or cow dung cakes. Master chefs have chipped in with tips on conserving fuel. Some advocate one-pot balanced meals, and reducing cooking time by soaking rice and lentils, fermenting ingredients and enhancing the dining pleasure by using freshly ground *chutneys* and spices pounded at home. One is grateful for all the advice but what is required is a fundamental shift in eating habits.

A NEW, HEALTHIER NORMAL

For much too long, we have been dangerously lazy. We have ceased to be mindful about what and how we eat. 'Organic' and 'vegan' are no longer buzzwords in passing vogue. Many in the younger generation put their trust in produce and products that identify as such. Unfortunately, not many of us read or decode labels. The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) struggles valiantly but not with much success.

Natural and Nature Identical cause much confusion; 'sugar free' doesn't cover invisible starchy sweeteners and trans-free doesn't mean that the vegetable oils used are free of health hazards. The proliferation of super processed foods is no less a problem. The alarming rise in child obesity, combined with malnutrition of infants and children in a vast segment of population, is distressing.

The sceptre of 'fuel famine' is akin to what the Covid pandemic had created. People had to devise survival strategies. Families were constrained to be frugal with provisions, innovate and improvise recipes and sharing chores. But as soon as the pandemic receded, things started sliding back to what shouldn't be accepted as the normal.

TANDOORI NIGHTS AND DAYS

India owns the largest reserves of coal in the world. Coal has traditionally fired *tandoors*, the clay ovens that can be traced back to the Indus Valley Civilisation and widely used in *angeethi* and *sighri* to chargrill succulent *kebabs* on skewers and myriad *tikkas*.

The iconic *dal makhni* is slow-cooked on dying embers of the *tandoor* and this is where brinjals were broiled for *bharta*. The *tandoor* was in the days past called *sanjha chulha* — a small community kitchen where village women brought dough kneaded at home to be baked as bread, *naan* or *parantha*.

In many parts, special breads like *sheermal*, *bakarkhani* and *roghani* continue to be bought from the *naanbai* — the professional baker presiding over a clay or iron *tandoor*. Kashmir, Lucknow, Rampur, Delhi and Hyderabad are renowned for assorted *kulcha*, *taftan*, *khameri rotis*. We are addicted to mass-produced bread and buns, *pav* and even *kulcha* and have forgotten our own, dare I say, energy-efficient *tandoor*.

PRESSURE OF THE COOKER

One recalls nostalgically the days when the great tech breakthrough, the pressure cooker, entered the kitchen. At first, only the affluent city-dwellers could afford it. It came with three or four flat-base pans that could be

arranged one on top of another and rice, *dal* and vegetables could be cooked simultaneously, saving both time and fuel. One wonders when and why this was forgotten.

Many cook a dozen or more *idlis* and *dhoklas* in a cooker in a jiffy, but few think of cooking three items together.

The microwave oven sits grandly in most kitchens, pressed into service only to heat dishes cooked earlier just before serving. This brings to mind Milton's oft-quoted lines in *Paradise Lost*: "They also serve who only stand and wait!" Time has come to use it as a convection oven, to boil and to grill.

Many gadget freaks have bought in haste air-fryers and induction cookers that sit like baby white elephants on kitchen shelves. Of this array of arsenal, the one that deserves special mention is the induction cooker. Why should it remain a prop on food shows orchestrated by celebrity chefs? Some may argue that it is beyond the reach of the subalterns who exist below the stratified middle classes. This is specious. Even shanties have TVs, fridges, mixies and are experts in maximising the benefits of available electricity.

IMPROVISING, INNOVATING

One-pot meals can come to our rescue, adding the joy of sharing forgotten recipes — some of them family heirlooms. The rising trend is to order *biryani handi* and *kebabs* for no-hassle hospitality for guests, also a practice in many families to give those who toiled in the kitchen a well-deserved rest.

Trying pot luck will doubtless add another layer of silver in the gathering dark clouds.

"Our grandparents cooked complete, nourishing meals without LPG — not as a

compromise, but as a way of life. Their methods offer us not nostalgia, but practical alternatives," says Chef and author Gunjan Goela. The key, she stresses, lies in planning: soaking lentils in advance, choosing dishes that require less cooking time, and preparing one-pot meals.

"There is also quiet wisdom in revisiting slow cooking. Dishes like *khichdi*, stews, or lightly spiced vegetables demand less constant fuel. Covered pots retain heat longer, reducing energy use. Even the residual warmth of a stove, once turned off, can be used to finish cooking," she says.

Equally important is a shift in mindset. "Seasonal produce cooks faster, tastes better, and requires fewer resources. Simple meals, thoughtfully prepared, can be deeply satisfying without being elaborate."

It's a thought seconded by Chef Izzat Hussain, heritage masterchef and physician: "It's crucial to share knowledge on cooking without fire, ensuring health and convenience for all. We need to explore alternatives like cold preparations such as salads, fruit chat, and fruit *chutneys*. There are traditional cooking mediums such as wood, *uple/kandey*, and charcoal. Among the efficient alternatives are microwave, induction cooking, and steam cooking. We can save fuel with pre-cooked ingredients like puff rice, roasted *chana*, roasted peanuts *sev*, *khakhra*, baked potatoes, etc."

SOLAR AND MORE

Not very long ago, the Prime Minister had initiated a campaign to establish an International Solar Alliance. How one wishes that the idea had gathered traction. Sun is worshipped with good reason. It is the source of all

energy. Our ancestors didn't have fancy solar cookers available with subsidies, but they had mastered the science of slow-cooking pickles and preserves by invisible heat. This technique was called *Nal Paak*, as it was believed to have been first used by the legendary king Nal. Memories of uncooked meals enjoyed many moons ago are stirring again — sprouts, salads like *kachumber* and *raitas* such as *pachadi* and *thecha raita*. The utensils that conjured magic can do so again in the present and future — *sil-batta*, *hamam dasta*, *mathani*. We don't have to depend on crutches of bottled salsa and pesto, dips and mayonnaise. All this stuff requires huge amounts of energy in factories. Not to forget the fuel consumed in transportation.

All of us should focus on eating mindfully and in a sustainable manner. We can begin with small steps. Buying fresh organic produce in *kisan mandis* is good for us, the farmers and the planet.

The crisis has come just as the weather is changing. This should reduce the urge (there is no real need for it) to reheat the food or to eat and drink everything piping hot.

By the way, we have always been intrigued by people on the other side of the spectrum who insist first on chilling water and beverages, then mixing it with water at room temperature before gulping it down.

There was a time when the fridge was primarily used to preserve left-over food or keep vegetables fresh. *Surahi* and *matka* were what provided cold water.

There is no lack of options. We just have to unshackle our minds from the vested interests in the oil and gas conglomerates. Let this wake-up call not go unheeded.

— The writer is a food historian

CAPTION CONTEST 1555



SANDEEP JOSHI

Entries are invited to suggest a caption for the photograph. The caption should only be in English, witty and not exceeding 10 words, and reach Spectrum, The Tribune, Chandigarh, 160030, by Thursday. The best five captions will be published and awarded ₹300, ₹250, ₹200, ₹150 and ₹100, respectively. Each caption must be accompanied by a clipping of the caption contest and its number. Photocopies or scans of the caption photo won't be accepted. Online subscribers may attach an epaper clipping at captionpics@tribunemail.com or a scanned copy of the e-paper clipping. Please mention the pin code and phone number in your address.

SELECTED ENTRIES FOR CAPTION CONTEST 1554



SPECTRUM MARCH 22 ISSUE (SEE PHOTO)

- Jobs and carriers — Dharuv Patwari via epaper, Gurdaspur
- Double engine start-up — Charandeep Shergill, Mohali
- Push for family business — Sanjay Chopra via epaper, Mohali
- Business on wheels — Karnail Singh, Kharar
- Push and pull strategy for sales — MR Virdi via epaper, Pathankot

When the sacred turns spectacle

Across the Himalayas, local traditions are facing pressures as they enter the digital mainstream

SUNEEL NEGI

HIGH in the trans-Himalayan district of Kinnaur in Himachal Pradesh, the village of Kalpa looks out upon the majestic Kinner Kailash range. For centuries, it has also looked inward — towards its own traditions, beliefs and rhythms of community life. Among these, the Raulane festival, observed during Paguli, remains one of the most distinctive expressions of a living cultural ethos.

Raulane is not merely a performance; it is a ritualised dialogue between the people and their sacred landscape. Through the characters of Raula and Raulane, villagers symbolically invoke the Saunis — spiritual entities believed to inhabit the surrounding mountains. Music, movement and costume come together to create a sacred theatre where faith is not displayed, but experienced.

There is also an element of quiet mystery: The Raulane, resplendent in elaborate attire and traditional jewellery, is portrayed by a young man whose identity remains concealed. The preparation — meticulously carried out by local women — underscores a deeper truth: that such traditions survive not through spectacle, but shared ownership and participation. This year, however, the festival told a more complex story.

Observed from March 5-10, Raulane drew an unprecedented number of visitors. Tourists, travel bloggers and social media influencers arrived in large numbers, many drawn by viral images and reels that have, over the past year, propelled this remote cultural practice into the digital spotlight.

At one level, this visibility is welcome. For long, many such traditions have remained confined to geographical margins. Social media, in this sense, has democratised cultural access. Yet, the events on the ground this year suggest that visibility, when not accompanied by sensitivity, can become intrusive.

The narrow temple precincts of Kalpa struggled to hold the surge of visitors. The festival, traditionally intimate in scale, appeared at moments to be overtaken by the crowd. Drones hovered overhead, documenting the event from above, while on the ground, indi-



viduals jostled for vantage points. In the process, something less tangible — but far more significant — seemed to recede: the quiet dignity of the tradition itself.

What was perhaps most telling was the discomfort among locals. Women assisting the performers, integral to the ritual process, were seen struggling to find space. For a community that has nurtured this tradition over generations, such displacement is not merely logistical — it is symbolic. There is, therefore, a larger question that Raulane compels us to confront: When does cultural documentation begin to distort the very culture it seeks to showcase?

The answer does not lie in rejecting visibility. Nor does it lie in romanticising isolation. Rather, it lies in acknowledging that not all cultural spaces are meant to function as open-ended spectacles. Some demand a measure of restraint — of both presence and portrayal.

Equally concerning is the emerging tendency among sections of content creators to prioritise virality over veracity. In simplifying or



The rhythmic movements of Raula and Raulane in Kalpa echo a deeper narrative — of a community holding onto its roots in a changing world.

PHOTOS BY THE WRITER

sensationalising elements of the festival, they risk reducing a layered cultural expression into consumable fragments. What is lost in the process is not just nuance, but authenticity.

If Raulane is to endure in its true form, a framework of shared responsibility must evolve. The local administration may need to consider basic crowd regulation and guidelines on the use of drones. Visitors must approach such spaces not as consumers of content, but as participants in a cultural experience that predates them. And those documenting it bear an added responsibility — to represent, not reinterpret, the tradition.

The story of Raulane is not unique. Across the Himalayas and beyond, many local traditions are encountering similar pressures as they enter the digital mainstream. The challenge, therefore, is not to resist change, but to shape it with care. For, in the end, Raulane is more than an event — it is an inheritance. Its value lies not in how widely it is seen, but in how faithfully it is preserved.

— The writer is Additional SP, Shimla

IMAGEin

A PHOTOGRAPH EXPLAINED

Elephant plinth supporting the main temple; Kailash, Cave 16.



Dancing Shiva in tandava; Kailash, Cave 16, Lankeshwar shrine.



The allure of ELLORA

A new book attempts the first systematic overview of the cave temples

OVER a thousand years ago, a quiet village named Elapura in the Western Ghats in Maharashtra was chosen to be the site where powerful dynasties would bring their best artists, artisans, and architects to showcase their talents and the devotion the kings and their subjects had for the gods of their faith. Over centuries, the site evolved, changing hands and faiths, and today it is home to some of the greatest Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain rock-cut cave temples in India.

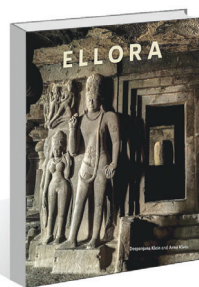
'Ellora', a new book by Deepanjana Klein and Arno Klein, attempts the first systematic overview of the Ellora cave temples, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, excavated between 600 CE and 1000 CE that are a stunning testament to ancient Indian art.

This volume brings a comprehensive understanding of the chronology and stylistic development of the 34 main caves and lesser caves of the site. Investigating each of the three groups of rock-cut temples by religion and myths, patronage and the economics of a monastery,

stylistic influence and exchange, and the process of carving and completion, the contributing authors reveal the integrity, the energy and the brilliance of Ellora.

The chapters offer a detailed study of the various facets. Deepanjana gives a peek into the Hindu temples. Nicholas Morrissey trains his focus on the Buddhist temples and Lisa N Owen on the Jain temples. Vidya Dehejia's 'Unfinished Work at Ellora' focuses on the caves that seem incomplete or those lacking in refinement. She seeks to know why should "unfinished" work matter and suggests that pre-modern India had a remarkably flexible and pragmatic approach towards the concept of finish.

The book includes extensive photographic documentation, ground plans, and rarely seen early 19th-century etchings of the most significant caves — from Thomas Daniell's hand-coloured aquatints (based on James Wales' drawings) to Raja Lala Deen Dayal's pioneering photographs; MF Pithawalla's detailed watercolours; and James Burgess' plans done for the Archaeological Survey of India. — TNS



ELLORA by Deepanjana Klein and Arno Klein.



Interior stupa with Buddha triad; Vishvakarma, Cave 10. All images from 'Ellora: Cross-Fertilization of Style in Buddhist, Hindu and Jain Cave Temples' by Deepanjana Klein and Arno Klein, published by Mapin Publishing. Photographs by Arno Klein.



Seated Buddhas; Tin Thal, Cave 12, third floor.

In a performance, light is not just illumination, it is interpretation

SPOTLIGHT

GYANDEV SINGH

EVERY year, when World Theatre Day arrives on March 27, we celebrate actors, playwrights, directors and audiences — the visible community of theatre. Yet there is another presence on stage that speaks constantly but is rarely acknowledged as a performer: That presence is light.

Most people assume lighting exists simply so that audiences can see the actor. But in theatre, light does much more than make things visible. Light interprets what we see. It shapes emotion before language begins. It creates atmosphere before a story unfolds. It quietly tells the audience what kind of world they have entered.

Light is not just illumination. It is interpretation. If you sit in a theatre just before the curtain rises, there is always a moment of anticipation. The stage may be empty. The actors have not yet entered. The story

has not begun. Yet something already starts happening. A faint glow appears. A colour settles over space. A shadow stretches across the floor. Without a single word being spoken, the audience senses whether they are entering a memory, a celebration, a conflict, or a prayer.

That is the work of light.

In my years of working across theatre and performance spaces, I have often felt that lighting behaves like a silent actor. It does not speak in sentences, but it communicates constantly. A soft amber wash can suggest warmth and belonging. A narrow shaft of white light can isolate a character in loneliness. A sudden darkness can create tension more effectively than dialogue ever can.

Sometimes audiences do not consciously notice lighting. But they always feel it.

In Indian performance traditions, this relationship between light and emotion has existed for centuries, even before modern lighting instruments appeared. Our classical arts have always understood that performance is not only about movement and text, but about mood. The *rasa* of a performance — whether it is devotion, longing, compassion, heroism or wonder — depends on atmosphere as much as action.

Lighting today continues that tradition in a contemporary form.

When I work on classical dance productions, I often think of light as a partner to the dancer rather than a background element. A dancer enters the stage carrying centuries of narrative memory. The lighting must respond to that presence with sensitivity. It must not dominate the performance, but it must support its emotional journey. Often the most powerful lighting choice is not the brightest one, but the quietest one. In theatre especially, light shapes space in ways audiences rarely notice consciously. A stage is physically limited by walls, curtains and architecture. But light-



Lighting quietly tells the audience what kind of world they have entered.

PHOTOS COURTESY: THE WRITER

ing can make that same stage feel like a palace, a forest, a courtyard or a solitary room. It can expand space or shrink it. It can guide the eye gently or suddenly redirect attention. It can make the audience feel close to a character or distant from them.

In this sense, lighting is not decoration. It is storytelling.

There is also something deeply human about theatre lighting that feels increasingly important in our digital age. Today we watch stories everywhere — on phones, on streaming platforms, on large screens. But theatre remains different because it is made of presence.

Actors are present. Audiences are present. And light itself is present in real time.

A lighting cue in theatre happens once, in that exact moment, for that exact audience. It cannot be paused, rewind or replayed. It exists only in the shared experience of performance. Perhaps this is why theatre continues to survive despite so many technological changes around us. It

reminds us that storytelling is not only about images. It is about encounter.

Lighting plays a quiet but essential role in creating that encounter.

People sometimes ask me what makes theatre lighting different from lighting in everyday life. My answer is simple. Everyday light reveals objects. Theatre light reveals meaning.

A doorway lit from behind becomes a memory. A face lit from the side becomes a question. A figure standing in darkness becomes a possibility.

These transformations happen not because of technology alone, but because of intention. Lighting design is not only about equipment. It is about listening carefully to the story, the performers and the space, and then responding with sensitivity. On World Theatre Day, we celebrate theatre as a collaborative art. No performance exists because of one individual alone. It is created through trust between many people working together — actors,

directors, musicians, designers, technicians and audiences. Lighting belongs to this collective spirit. It does not demand attention for itself. Instead, it supports others in being seen more truthfully.

Perhaps that is why lighting often remains invisible as an art form. When it works well, it disappears into the experience. The audience remembers the emotion of the scene, not the instrument that created it. Yet without light, theatre would remain incomplete. As we celebrate theatre this year, it may be worth pausing for a moment before the curtain rises — in that quiet space between darkness and performance — and noticing how the first gesture of storytelling often arrives not through words or movement, but through light. Because before the actor speaks, before the music begins, and before the story unfolds, theatre always starts with illumination becoming interpretation.

— The writer is a National Award-winning lighting and spatial designer based in Chandigarh

A face lit from the side becomes a question. A figure standing in darkness becomes a possibility.



Setting record straight on China’s ruling party

DEVENDRA KUMAR

XI JINPING, in his speech on the occasion of the 100th anniversary of the Communist Party of China (CPC) in 2021, asserted that “in 1921, as the Chinese people and the Chinese nation were undergoing a great awakening and Marxism-Leninism was becoming closely integrated with the Chinese workers’ movement, the Communist Party of China was born”. The claim that the CPC had wide support since its inception is not new, but underpins the broader political claim that its rise was inevitable.

Frank Dikötter’s writings have long questioned the official history by relying on suppressed accounts of the CPC’s policies in his work over the last three decades. His latest book, ‘Red Dawn Over China’, counters the many claims.

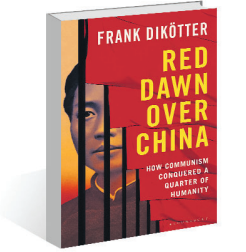
Communist ideology, he writes, was imposed on the Chinese people rather than the CPC being the political articulator of the ideological beliefs of a majority of them. The author convincingly shows through the party’s own official reports of the era that it did not have a significant membership and lacked an effective organisation on the ground except in Soviet areas, which different leaders such as Mao Zedong in the eastern province of Jiangxi controlled. As a

result, the CPC leadership, guided and supported by the Soviet-led Comintern, struggled to find its foothold until the late 1930s.

Further, the balance of power among major European powers, Japan, and the Soviet Union determined the dynamics between the Nationalist Party (KMT) and the Communists, which ultimately shaped the course of the rise of the CPC from near oblivion in the mid-1930s. Thus, there was nothing inevitable about the CPC’s victory in the civil war with the KMT (1945-1949).

Two, the word communism featured in the CPC’s lexicon only in 1926. Until then, Bolshevism — a radical faction that ultimately won the Russian Revolution and founded the Soviet Union — was often used to define its ideology. In the absence of ideological convictions among its rank and file and the public, the CPC adopted brutal violence as a key means to get its way, whether to compel people under its control to submit to its will or in its negotiations and power struggle with the KMT.

Communism thus rose gradually into an official ideology in China, its contents determined either through power struggles among the elites or practical necessities. Thus, Soviet agents determined the ideological lines and power balance among key leaders until the late 1930s, with the Soviet brand of communism dominating the official policy. However, that changed with



RED DAWN OVER CHINA
by Frank Dikötter.
Bloomsbury.
Pages 384.
₹445.

Frank Dikötter’s writings have long questioned the official history by relying on suppressed accounts of the CPC’s policies

Mao’s rise from 1937 onwards, and a new ideology, Mao Zedong Thought, emerged through a brutal political struggle between Mao and the Soviet-trained Wang Ming.

Still, even a large section of its own members followed leaders without having any deep ideological convictions. As a result, Chinese communism has always been susceptible to elite power struggles and amenable to taking into account practical necessities, such as co-opting ethnic groups in the 1940s or shifting towards reforms and opening up despite both occurring without acknowledgement of the communist doctrine. It continues to be defined by who is ruling and their methods of rule.

Three, the CPC has always been conscious of its image and has invested heavily in shaping it among the international audience. Dikötter provides meticulous details about its efforts to present itself as a viable option, in contrast to the KMT’s rule of China. That major powers such as the US considered the CPC more democratic during the civil war was the result of its leadership’s strenuous efforts. To the US representatives in the 1940s, Zhou Enlai went so far as to claim that the CPC wanted a constitutional government like the US had. That the external-facing posture of an open, more benign political force contradicted indiscriminate violence it adopted during that time is not an aberration.

Rather, except perhaps during the Cultural Revolution (1966-1976) when it was largely isolated internationally, the duality of internal authoritarianism and external benign attitude has been an integral part of the CPC leadership’s strategy to navigate domestic and international challenges, to this day.

Despite laborious work, the book at times uncritically uses sources such as the perspectives of the representatives of major powers and other non-Chinese individuals. As a result, it tends to present the interests of major powers such as the US and European powers as benign players, which certainly was not the case.

However, the book is useful for a wide range of audiences, both lay and expert. It offers fresh perspectives based on a new corpus of primary documents, contemporary accounts by individuals who were part of the events or were observers, and official assessments by other major powers.

Given that the CPC remains a top-down Leninist institution, the book also provides a guide to contemporary developments, such as elite power struggles and the exercise of power within the vast and complex organisation.

— *The reviewer is Associate Fellow at the Centre of Excellence for Himalayan Studies, Shiv Nadar Institution of Eminence, Delhi-NCR*

Between hope & exhaustion

DEEPSHIKHA BHARDWAJ

IN ‘Whatever it Takes’, author Sangeetha Chakrapani sits beside you to narrate a story that almost every parent raising a child with special needs would relate to. In this moving memoir, she recounts every tear shed, every step taken forward, the deep hurt, and the acute embarrassment that lies behind the “plastic smile” which almost never fails to fool the perfect world.

The author begins her narrative with the lengths she went to, to fulfil her intense desire to become a mother very early in her marriage.

Sangeetha accepts she did not use common sense when she allowed a nurse to decide on the treatment in the absence of the doctor. Without overwhelming the reader, she then recounts how having four children through intrauterine insemination (IUI) — two of them on spectrum and one needing extensive medical care — redefined everything, including the much-less-talked-about equation between a couple and even the shift in her role from a mother to more of a manager.

The strain and silence that can enter a relationship under pressure are acknowledged without bitterness. She writes of partnership not as a fixed state, but as something that must be renegotiated, reshaped, and sometimes rebuilt. These moments feel honest, even brave, in their refusal to idealise.

She beautifully captures the everyday — the small victories that feel immense, the setbacks that arrive without warning, and the exhaustion that lingers beneath routine as life becomes less about expectation

and more about adaptation.

Gently but firmly, Sangeetha holds your hand and walks you through the different shades of neurodiversity. With care and a disarming simplicity, she makes you live the shifts to find a balance, learning and unlearning, hope and despair, discovering the extraordinary strength, revisiting decisions, and the what ifs.

The soul of this journey lies in the deep faith she finds in Sai Baba. The faith which found its roots in the heart that sank several times, beginning with the diagnosis, but had to be strong enough to give unconditional love and fight social judgment.

What draws you in further is the answer to the question which most parents carry, but cannot answer — who after me will care for this vulnerable human being? It is not a go-to guide but does tell you that progress may not always be visible and joy can be found in the most unexpected places.

The small, tell-tale anecdotes in the second half of the book bear testament that a life that seems limited, impossible and irreversible can be lived beautifully and meaningfully. That almost never prim and proper homes, which could be easily judged for storing clothes in plastic buckets, have so much going. What it takes is courage, acceptance, help, and a never-die attitude.

My takeaway from the book comes right at the end. When restraint breaks. When the narrative finds a turning point. And stops asking for a different life. “Give me my life back,” she writes — a line that repeats, gathers weight, and refuses to be softened.

This is not resilience. This is grief stripped of language. Not just for what is, but for what will never be. And then, quietly, the question dissolves. Life does not come back. Instead, the narrative shifts. From loss to construction, from longing to a harder, clearer task: how to live within what remains.

— *The reviewer is a freelance journalist*

Textures of immigrant life

SUPRIYA KAUR DHALIWAL

SUSHAM BEDI’S ‘The Fire Sacrifice’, translated from Hindi, offers a psychologically rich portrait of migration, tracing the disorienting journey of Guddo, a North Indian widow who relocates to the US in search of economic stability and dignity. The novel’s strength lies in its unflinching attention to the textures of immigrant life — the claustrophobia of shared apartments, the precarity of low-wage work, and the slow erosion of familial bonds under economic pressure.

Guddo emerges as a deeply compelling narrator: reliable, perceptive, and often painfully self-aware. She is acutely conscious of her conservative North Indian upbringing — its hierarchies, its expectations of womanhood, and its emphasis on familial duty. Yet what makes her character striking is the way she simultaneously inhabits and resists these structures. Migration, for Guddo, is not simply geographic but ethical and psychological. In America, she is forced to renegotiate her identity — not as someone’s wife or elder sister, but as an individual navigating labour, survival, and dignity on her own terms.

Guddo’s experience of America is marked by a persistent critical distance. She does not romanticise the promise of the West; instead, she observes its harsh capitalism with clarity. The “rat race” she becomes part of is relentless and dehumanising, reducing her to a body that labours, commutes, and endures.

The novel is particularly effective in showing how immigration often entails a downward social mobility that contradicts the myth of upward economic aspiration. Guddo, once the wife of a respected engineer in India, finds herself selling newspapers in a subway booth.

However, the novel’s use of Vedic *mantras* as recurring interludes feels uneven. While they are clearly intended to frame Guddo’s inner life — offering a spiritual vocabulary through which she processes suffering and desire — they often read as interruptions

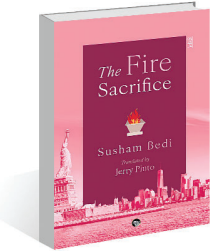
rather than organic extensions of the narrative. For readers not invested in their symbolic resonance, these moments can feel detached, breaking the emotional continuity of Guddo’s story rather than deepening it. The tension between the sacred and the mundane is conceptually interesting, but not always fully realised at the level of form.

What remains most powerful is the novel’s depiction of kinship under strain. Guddo’s relationship with her sisters is rendered with painful nuance. The intimacy of shared history is gradually corroded by financial dependence, resentment, and the pressures of migrant life. Bedi resists easy moral binaries here: no one is entirely right or wrong. Instead, the novel reveals how structural conditions — scarcity and aspiration — reshape even the most intimate familial bonds.

‘The Fire Sacrifice’ is less about assimilation than about endurance. Guddo’s journey is not one of triumphant reinvention, but of incremental survival. In this sense, the novel offers a sobering counter-narrative to dominant stories of migration, foregrounding the emotional and ethical costs of starting over.

Despite some formal unevenness, Bedi’s work remains a quietly devastating exploration of displacement, resilience, and the fragile negotiations of selfhood in a capitalist world which can never be our home.

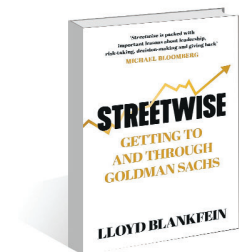
— *The reviewer is a literary translator*



THE FIRE SACRIFICE
by Susham Bedi. Translated by Jerry Pinto.
Speaking Tiger.
Pages 232. ₹499

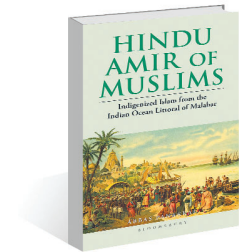


BACKFLAP



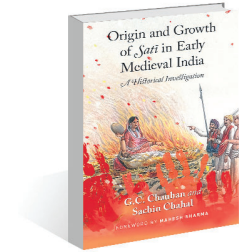
STREETWISE
by Lloyd Blankfein.
Hachette.
Pages 400. ₹799

This is an honest, sharp and often funny reckoning with investment banker Lloyd Blankfein’s education in finance, human nature and the workings of the world. It abounds with lessons about leading teams of brilliant, aggressive, competitive people and harmonising them around shared goals; changing when times are hard and when they’re good; managing risk; and knowing a crisis is at hand before it swamps you.



HINDU AMIR OF MUSLIMS
by Abbas Panakkal.
Bloomsbury.
Pages 278. ₹1,599

Through a detailed examination of popular traditions, primary texts, and archaeological and architectural artifacts, this book explores the pivotal role of integration in shaping indigenised Islam in 16th-century Malabar. It seeks to unravel historical processes that facilitated the fusion of Islam within the vernacular context. It navigates the various pathways through which Malabar Islam emerged as a unique blend of indigenous cultural expressions within the broader Islamic heritage.



ORIGIN AND GROWTH OF SATI IN EARLY MEDIEVAL INDIA
by GC Chauhan and Sachin Chahal.
Sanctum Books.
Pages 237. ₹1,495

This book traces the evolution of Sati from a rare and voluntary act to a more institutionalised and widespread ritual, particularly among the upper social strata. It examines the social and economic forces that contributed to its proliferation, including the emergence of warrior and royal cultures, inheritance disputes, and the consolidation of patriarchal norms.

Ways that nurture humanity



TOUCHSTONES
IRA PANDE

AS I was cleaning up my phone recently, deleting old photos and those irritating Good Morning forwards that just clog up space, I chanced upon a stunning article written by Aatish Taseer for *Vanity Fair* in 2019, titled *A Rake's Progress*. It was a deep, psycho-political dive into the life and times of Pakistan's Imran Khan, surely one of the most iconic political figures of our subcontinent and a man imprisoned by the present Pakistani government for reasons that have never made sense. Ironically, for a man who was as admired by our cricket-crazy Indian *janta* as well as his legion admirers abroad, no one has spoken about the inhuman conditions he has had to endure during his solitary confinement.

I began to reflect whether it is a reluctance (understandable perhaps) here in India to interfere in the political affairs of a neighbouring country, or whether it is a convenient excuse offered by those in power who are elected by us to speak out on what are considered 'difficult' subjects. This is true not just of our government but of all those across the world who have allowed Trump and Netanyahu on one hand and Iran's leaders to hold the world to ransom. Worse, they have remained resolutely silent over the killing of civilians and, horrifyingly, of more than 160 schoolgirls. None of us are unaware of how many children have been orphaned, how many women widowed, how many homes and lives destroyed. And yet, we make *tch-tch* sounds and continue to view reels of the daily spectacle of flying missiles and drones while we munch popcorn in front of our TVs.

Are we so dehumanised now that nothing that

does not directly affect our lives moves us? Or have we surrendered our own conscience to our respective governments to deal with questions of ethics, morality and humanity?

Perhaps it is because we have shrunk ourselves into nuclear families and nuclear states (no pun intended). But please remember that by their very nature, nuclear units atomise into smaller and smaller units. So, in India, we have carved up a syncretic land into linguistic states and these are now divided according to regions. The South considers itself to be no part of the land that lies north of the Vindhya, while the eastern states are embroiled in ugly arguments over who has a legitimate dominion

Somewhere, there is the absence of a common language of universal emotions and an ethical foundation

status. Let's not even talk of Bengal that has never surrendered its identity to India. Kashmir? I'll say no more.

Somewhere, there is the absence of a common language of universal emotions and an ethical foundation. There was a time when one's mother tongue was more important than the *lingua franca* being promoted in our schools. My mother understood this, having been exposed to so many different languages as she and her siblings went from Gujarat to Kumaon, to Bundelkhand and Rampur and then to Santiniketan to become fluent in Hindi, Urdu, Sanskrit, Kumaoni, Gujarati, Bengali, Marathi, English, Avadhi and Bundelkhandi as well.

My generation may have lost a few of that huge palette of languages but retains several and added some (Punjabi in my case). My comfort level in English is undeniable but I have still kept up my reading in Hindi and speak in Kumaoni to my siblings and cousins. And I can tell you that if my transla-

tion skills are valued today, it is in no small measure to my mother's insistence that we speak the language of the common man. She taught us to add, rather than drop, languages as we went along our lives.

In her last years, my mother spent more and more time in Lucknow and became a sort of fixture of the literary fraternity there. People came to meet her and learn from her but she never stopped learning herself.

Every morning, she sat on her terrace, surrounded by her staff and a curious fan club that included Ramrati, her faithful maid, her children and grandchildren, Burho, an old crone who came because she had nowhere else to go, her *rickshawala* Qutb Ali, her sweeper Mohan and wife Bahuriya, even a monkey called Ramkali who sat in her *puja* and put out a paw to receive some *prasad* at the end. My mother was convinced Ramkali was a failed writer and read her newspaper upside down with Shivani's reading glasses perched on her face.

Who knows whether this was true or another one of my mother's extraordinary stories?

Yet this woman, who listened intently to her *dhobi* Misrilal's weekly saga of unhappiness at the hands of an uncaring daughter-in-law, was equally at home in the company of Acharya Hajari Prasad Dwivedi, Amritlal Nagar, Mahadevi Verma and Sumitranandan Pant. Her greatest takeaway from her time at Tagore's *ashram* and its liberal education was to remain a learner who listened intently to all those around her. Who can say whether the stories she has left behind had real characters behind them, but to date all her readers stoutly believe that she was an extraordinary teller of tales who could make you believe in whatever she wrote.

Our conversations with the people amongst whom we live are essential to understand the human conditions that are universal. Reaching out to strangers, chatting with lonely folk, even just a smile to people you meet on your morning walk, connects you in ways that nurture humanity.

Remember that.

— The writer is a social commentator

Wars, ecocide and the Doomsday Clock



AVAY SHUKLA

IT'S a disturbing sign of the times that the global levers of power today are controlled by genocidal murderers, sex-offenders, megalomaniac sociopaths, war criminals and rapacious billionaires who should all be in jail.

Collectively, these psychopaths are driving the human race ever closer to the seventh mass extermination, this time of *homo sapiens* — which is probably a good thing from a planetary perspective, for we do not deserve this wonderful orb. Any one of three forces — artificial intelligence (AI), climate change, war — has the capacity to exterminate us, but it gets even worse. The last three years have demonstrated that all these three forces are now coming together to do the job.

As we edge ever closer to a war-driven holocaust in Ukraine and the Middle East, this three-way synergy is becoming more pronounced and evident. AI is being used to assassinate leaders, military chiefs and scientists, to communicate and do surveillance, to guide missiles and bombs, to make war itself autonomous.

The fate of "enemies" is now being decided by algorithms, not rational persons. This harnessing of AI for war has been exposed in the tussle between Anthropic and the Pentagon, when the latter refused to accept the guardrails which Anthropic had inserted into its algorithms to prevent their misuse. Anthropic was blacklisted for taking an ethical stand, but Open AI and others quickly filled the void. AI is making even conventional/non-nuclear wars more lethal and opportunistic/acceptable for those nations which possess the technology.

This AI is being used by robber baron warlords, criminal syndicates masquerading as elected governments, to wage illegal wars, driving us ever closer to climate Armageddon by destroying the natural environment, increasing the emission of GHGs (green house gases), and polluting the soils and waters of a dozen nations. Sadly, however, no one is talking about the environmental catastrophe unfolding in larger concentric circles; all eyeballs are fixated on missiles, drones, aircraft carriers and the Strait of Hormuz.

A study has revealed that three years of the Russia-Ukraine war have released an additional 350 million tonnes of pollutants/GHG/CO₂ into the atmosphere — 1 per cent of annual global emissions — through bombings, explosions and fires.

The destruction of the Kakhovka dam in Kherson region of Ukraine by Russia in 2023 flooded 600+ sq km of the downstream area, causing a humanitarian and ecological disaster on an unparalleled scale. More than 83,000 tonnes of silt contaminated with heavy metals (lead, cadmium, nickel) has been deposited downstream, making the soil and water there toxic and poisoned for decades.

The entire 365 sq km of the Gaza Strip has been carpet-bombed by Israel to an extent that there is now no

farmland or green area remaining there. Thousands of unexploded ordnance are buried in its soil and cities; 80 per cent of all buildings in Gaza have been destroyed, and according to an estimate by the United Nations, this has created 63 million tonnes of rubble, which will take 15 years to remove if 200 truckloads are removed every day! The cost will be more than a billion US dollars. Effectively, the entire 365 sq km has been degraded into a wasteland.

The environmental impact of the ongoing US/Israel war on Iran will be much worse, both for the land and the sea, especially now that oil facilities are fair game for all parties. Israel initiated this new phase of environmental warfare by bombing Tehran's oil storage tanks in the second week of March: the resultant massive plumes of black smoke which persisted for days were bad enough. Worse was the rain that fell, "black rain" containing all the released pollutants which have now leached into the soil, making it toxic and barren for decades, and contaminating the ground water.

Israel's attack on Iran's Pars gas field on March 18 is the beginning of an ecocide in the whole region: it processes 600 million cubic metres of natural gas every day. With such a humongous volume being set on fire, the toxic fumes will envelop not only Iran but the entire Gulf region, and could travel even as far as Pakistan and India. Iran's inevitable retaliation by bombing the oil fields of Israel and the Gulf countries will exponentially multiply this pollution.

One shudders to even imagine how much pollutants all this will add to the atmosphere.

Tens of millions of litres/barrels of oil are contained in the ships, both military and civilian, sailing in the Persian Gulf, all in harm's way. More than 13 million barrels of oil and 5,00,000 tonnes of gas are presently locked up in the Strait of Hormuz alone in 300 ships. If even half a dozen of them are sunk, the waters of the Gulf shall be contaminated for decades, all marine life destroyed.

Have we forgotten what happened during the Iraq war, when Saddam Hussein spilled millions of litres of oil into the sea? That marine area has yet to recover, even after decades.

A recent study quoted in *The Guardian* reveals that 5 million tonnes of CO₂ have been emitted in the first 14 days of the current war; from destroyed buildings (2.4 million tonnes), fuel for military vehicles (52,900 tonnes), bombing of oil facilities (1.88 million tonnes), destroyed military hardware (1,72,000 tonnes), munitions (55,000 tonnes). This is equivalent to the annual carbon budget of the 84 lowest carbon-emitting countries.

The Netanyahus, Putins and Trumps of the world are not only waging illegal wars and trashing humanitarian covenants, they are committing ecocide on a horrendous scale. This is another reminder that fossil-fuelled geopolitics is incompatible with a liveable planet. The Doomsday Clock in Chicago University, which is so set up that midnight signifies total Apocalypse, is getting ever closer to that point in time. It was at 17 minutes to midnight in 1991, today it is at 85 seconds to midnight. The world is running out of time fast, and that is not just a metaphor.

— The writer is a retired IAS officer

Upanishads as against Dharma-shastra

IN the Upanishads, the word Brahmin is about inner realisation. In Dharma-shastra, the word Brahmin is about birth status and purity. The early Upanishads were composed between 600 BC and 200 BC, while the early Dharma-shastra were composed between 200 BC and 500 AD. The former is more spiritual. The latter is more legal.

Strict rules of marriage based on caste are promoted by Dharma-shastra. This idea is not present in Upanishads. In fact, as per genetic studies, endogamy in India began only 1,900 years ago (70 generations ago), which scientifically proves this dramatic social shift which changed Hinduism forever. It is this new form of Hinduism that Brahmins took with them beyond Arya-varta to the river valleys of South and East India, when they were forced to leave North India following Huna invasions and loss of patronage to Buddhists and Jains.

In the Chandogya Upanishad, a boy named Satyakama approaches the teacher Gautama and asks to be accepted as a student. Gautama asks about his lineage. Satyakama repeats what his mother told: she had many lovers so does not know who the father is. Gautama declares: only a true Brahmin can speak such uncompromising truth. He accepts the boy as a student. Here, truthfulness, not pedigree, marks Brahminhood.

Raikva, a humble cart driver, refuses to reveal the secrets of Upanishad to King Janashruti in exchange for money. But when the king offers his daughter, thus welcoming him as a family member, overcoming caste and class prejudices, the knowledge is revealed.

Contrast this with the Dharma-shastra world.



UNIVERSE

DEVDUTT PATTANAİK

In the 21st century, Hindus quote Upanishads but their social behaviour is aligned to Dharma-shastra

In the Manusmriti, Brahmin is defined by birth into a particular *varna*. Duties are listed: study and teach the Veda, perform and officiate sacrifices, accept and give gifts. Detailed rules govern marriage alliances, food restrictions, inheritance, and punishment. If a Brahmin commits a crime, the penalty may be lighter than for a Shudra committing the same offence. Social order rests on graded inequality.

There are stories that illustrate this legalistic framework. The tale of Shambuka in the

Ramayana tradition shows a Shudra performing austerities reserved for higher *varnas*. His *tapas* is seen as a violation of cosmic order. The king intervenes violently, kills Shambuka, to restore *dharma*. Here *dharma* is tied to fixed social roles, not inner quest.

Similarly, in Manusmriti discussions, mixed marriages produce named categories of offspring, each assigned specific occupations. Identity becomes a matter of regulated descent. The concern is not realisation of Brahman but the preservation of hierarchy. Krishna is always referred to as a cowherd, as he is raised by cowherds. Karna is always referred to as charioteer, as he is raised by charioteers. Draupadi refuses to consider Karna for marriage as he is of inferior birth.

In Bhakti lore, saints considered impure are not allowed to enter temples. Across India, in temples like Jagannath Puri and Pandharpur, there are shrines at temple gates reminding all of those who were not allowed to enter the temple on grounds of impure birth.

Thus, the Upanishadic imagination opens Brahminhood to anyone who embodies truth and insight. The Dharma-shastra imagination closes it within birth, rule, and privilege. One tells stories of seekers who transcend status. The other tells stories of order threatened when status is crossed.

In the 21st century, Hindus quote Upanishads to prove the greatness of their faith, but their social behaviour is aligned to Dharma-shastra. Social media is full of popular gurus who speak of the glory of Brahmin birth. That is unfortunate.

— The writer is an acclaimed mythologist

Talking to ghosts in English, a migrant's worst fear



SANTOSH JATRANA

ONE morning, we got a message from one of my husband's friends from India. He now lives in Perth, while we are in Melbourne. The message was simple: "In Melbourne today, let's meet." Naturally, a Haryanvi reunion cannot happen over Zoom or a casual coffee. It needs a proper setting, so we met in a bar.

The moment we started speaking in Haryanvi, the atmosphere changed. Any one who understands the language knows

that Haryanvi is not just a dialect — it is a philosophy of life. It has a rare ability to find humour even in the most uncomfortable or tragic moments.

We were laughing about this when our friend shared an incident from his life.

A few years ago, his father passed away in India. As the eldest son, he flew from Australia to perform the last rites. At the cremation ground, surrounded by relatives and neighbours, he tried to light the funeral pyre. Unfortunately, things were not going smoothly. The fire would not catch. Someone in the crowd commented that he clearly did not know how to do it properly.

Without missing a beat, he replied: "Mahare ke raj mara kara?" (Do people in our family die every day that I should already know how to do this?)

That story reminded me of my own father. A few months before he passed

away, I advised him, with the seriousness of a dutiful daughter, that he should start remembering God more often.

"You should take God's name regularly," I told him.

He listened quietly and then replied in his usual style: "Ab to mil he lenge... ab

Anyone who understands the language knows that Haryanvi is not just a dialect — it is a philosophy of life

naam lena ka kya fayda?" (I'll meet Him soon anyway — what's the point of just taking His name now?)

Such is the Haryanvi approach to existential philosophy: practical, direct, and slightly mischievous.

As the evening progressed, our conversation drifted to the pros and cons of leaving India. We were very well established in India. Australia has also been good to us; professionally, we are settled and lead fulfilling lives. Yet sometimes I still feel an urge to return to India.

When I mentioned this, our friend looked puzzled.

"Why do you want to go back?" he asked. "You don't even have a problem with English." I wondered what English had to do with anything.

He then narrated another classic Haryanvi story.

A couple they knew in Australia lived in

a house that desperately needed renovation. One day, their grandfather, visiting from India, asked the wife directly why they didn't renovate.

Her answer was perfectly logical. In a Haryanvi way.

"Our children are well settled," she said. "After retirement, we will go back to India anyway. What's the point of renovating? We don't want to die here."

But then she added with complete seriousness: "More piche bhoota se bhi angreji bolni paragi" (After death, we'll even have to speak in English with the ghosts!)

Perhaps that is the real genius of Haryanvi humour. Only a Haryanvi mind can worry about language barriers, even in afterlife. After all, if ghosts truly exist, one must at least ensure they speak the right language.

— The writer is a professor at Deakin University, Australia

The ruling that SC status applies only to Hindus, Sikhs and Buddhists and conversion will lead to its forfeiture confronts a complex reality in Punjab

Caste, religion, social justice & law

DEEPAKAMAL KAUR

A LONG-STANDING and sensitive debate concerning religion, caste, social justice, and the law has been reignited following two significant developments in the recent past.

On March 24, the Supreme Court of India reaffirmed that under the Constitution (Scheduled Castes) Order of 1950, the Scheduled Caste (SC) status is reserved exclusively for individuals practising Hinduism, Sikhism, or Buddhism. The court also clarified that conversion to other religions, including Christianity, would result in the automatic forfeiture of this status and its associated benefits.

Just 10 days before the Supreme Court's ruling, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, speaking at a rally in Moga, announced that the Bharatiya Janata Party would introduce a stringent anti-conversion law if it formed the government in Punjab in 2027. These developments have sparked strong reactions from the Christian community in the state.

Many marginalised Dalits have been gravitating toward Christianity in Punjab, seeking a way out of caste-based discrimination. Members of the community have called for the protection of SC status for those converting to Christianity, arguing that the current legal framework presents a significant barrier for Dalits wishing to leave Hinduism or Sikhism.

The 'Dalit Christians' are caught between caste-based discrimination and religious identity. Their decision to convert has led to a complex legal and social dilemma — while Christianity promises spiritual equality, it does not automatically grant Dalits the same rights and privileges they enjoyed under the SC status in the Hindu and Sikh fold.

Tarsem Peter, a Catholic and Dalit activist from Jalandhar, has urged the Christian community not to be swayed by the "growing phobia in the wake of the Supreme Court judgment". He emphasises that the court's decision pertains only to a specific case (*Chinthada Anand vs State of Andhra Pradesh*) and does not yet address the broader issue of extending Dalit rights to converted Christians.

Peter points out that a three-member commission, headed by former Chief Jus-



Punjab is seeing a growing number of churches, many led by pastors from Hindu, Khatri, Jat Sikh, and other communities, which function like *deras*. TRIBUNE PHOTO

tice of India KG Balakrishnan, was established in October 2022 to examine the feasibility of granting SC status to Dalits who convert to religions other than Hinduism, Sikhism, or Buddhism, including Christianity and Islam. "The commission is still conducting research on the socio-economic and historical conditions of these converts," Peter says, stressing that the fight for rights is far from over.

However, the Protestant community has a different perspective. Rohit Masih Avraham, a lawyer and representative of the Youth Punjab Christian Movement, has welcomed the Supreme Court's ruling, viewing it as a step toward transparency and fairness.

He argues that the ruling addresses the long-standing issue of dual identities, where religious affiliation and legal identity diverge. This, he says, has led to distortions in census data and political underrepresentation of the Christian community in Punjab. Avraham points out that while many people convert to Chris-

tianity and embrace the faith's rituals, they often refrain from registering themselves as Christians in official records to maintain Scheduled Caste benefits, including reservations in education, jobs, and other welfare schemes.

BJP leader Vijay Sampla, former chairperson of the National Commission for Scheduled Castes, supports the Supreme Court's clarification. He argues that individuals who convert to Christianity in search of freedom from caste discrimination must accept the implications of that conversion, which include abandoning their SC status and the associated benefits.

Jasvir S Garhi, chairman of the Punjab State Commission for Scheduled Castes, echoes this sentiment, saying that those who choose Christianity, a religion he describes as "caste-free", should no longer claim to be Dalits or retain the benefits that come with that status.

Critics argue that the laws surrounding caste and conversion are vague, confusing,

and open to misuse. They caution that extending SC status to all Dalits, including those who have converted to other religions, could complicate the reservation system. Ramesh Chander, a former Indian Foreign Service officer and blogger on Dalit issues, expresses the view that individuals cannot claim the rights and benefits of their previous faith while simultaneously converting to another religion.

The issue has also been compounded by a growing number of churches in Punjab, many led by pastors from Hindu, Khatri, Jat Sikh, and other communities, which function like *deras*. These churches are attracting large numbers of people, particularly from rural and semi-rural areas, but also from urban localities. This expansion has raised concerns among some sections of the population.

Former Punjab Chief Minister and prominent Dalit leader Charanjit Singh Channi emphasises the need for introspection among Hindu and Sikh religious leaders regarding why so many

marginalised Dalits are turning to Christianity. He argues that the core issue for Dalits is a search for dignity within their own communities.

Historian Dr Satish K Kapoor suggests that every religion, including Islam and Christianity, has internal divisions. "There are Shias and Sunnis among the Muslims. According to studies, there are as many as 36,000 denominations among the Christians. People within the same religion often form separate factions."

Dr Kapoor says that while conversions may lead to demographic imbalances and socio-political conflicts, the focus should be on fostering brotherhood to reduce the need for conversion in the first place.

Ultimately, he says, the controversy over 'Dalit Christians' and their SC status is not just about legal technicalities or religious conversions. It raises deeper questions about India's constitutional vision of equality and how it can adapt to the evolving social realities of caste, religion, and identity in contemporary India.

They don't shoot, speak or even exist, yet AI-powered creators are building massive audiences and fortunes online

The rise of invisible content creators

#tech tonic
GAGANDEEP ARORA

SOMEWHERE on YouTube right now, a channel is pulling in millions of views. There's no presenter, no camera crew, no makeup artist and no studio. There isn't even a real person behind the content. Welcome to the strange, lucrative and slightly unsettling world of faceless artificial intelligence (AI) content creation.

Picture this: a 22-year-old college dropout sitting with a laptop, running multiple YouTube channels and Instagram accounts, earning between ₹5 lakh and ₹15 lakh a month with operating costs of just ₹60,000-80,000. No camera. No lighting rig. Just AI tools and a system that turns ideas into videos for as little as ₹6,000 each. This is not hypothetical. Creators like Caleb Boxx and Adavia Davis run AI-powered video networks generating around 2 million views a day. Scripts come from AI, narration from tools like ElevenLabs and videos are assembled almost automatically.

A Kapwing (a researcher in digital media space) analysis of 15,000 top YouTube channels shows the scale. AI-driven content has already generated over 63 billion views, 221 million subscribers and roughly ₹1,050 crore annually in ad revenue. The invisible creator is no longer an experiment. It is an industry.

GIANTS WHO NEVER SHOW UP

Faceless content isn't entirely new. Channels like *Bright Side* (44 million subscribers), *The Infographics Show* and *Daily Dose of Internet* built massive audiences without a visible host. Even *Kurzgesagt* turned animation into a science storytelling powerhouse. Then came scale. Channels like *'DaFuq? Boom!'* turned bizarre concepts like *'Skibidi Toilet'* into global phenomena, earning crores monthly.

The formula is simple. Strong hooks, endless output and no dependence on personality.

INFLUENCERS WHO DON'T EXIST

Instagram has taken things further by not just remov-

ing faces, but creating entirely fictional people. Lil Miquela collaborates with luxury brands. Lu do Magalu has over 8.7 million followers. Shudu, the world's first digital supermodel, has appeared in *Vogue*. Spain's Aitana López reportedly earns lakhs every month. India is catching up quickly. AI influencers like Kyra and Naina Avtr are building digital identities rooted in fashion, travel and lifestyle. They post, promote and engage like any human influencer, except they don't exist.

INDIA'S AI CONTENT BOOM

The shift is even more striking on YouTube. The Indian channel *'Bandar Apna Dost'* has amassed over 2 billion views and generates an estimated ₹38 crore annually. It produces hundreds of short, emotionally-driven AI-generated videos optimised for attention, not depth.

India's vast audience, low costs and growing creator economy make it an ideal testing ground for this model.

WHY EVERYONE IS JUMPING IN

The appeal is obvious. AI has drastically lowered the barrier to entry. No camera, no studio, no performance skills required. Production is faster. A traditional creator might post a few times a week, but an AI-driven channel can post daily or even multiple times a day.

For brands, the economics is irresistible. AI models don't demand fees, don't age and don't create controversies. The result: a content gold rush.

HOW IT ACTUALLY WORKS

At its core, faceless content creation is more assembly line than art studio. A creator picks a niche like finance, history, crime or motivation and uses tools like ChatGPT to generate scripts. Platforms such as InVideo, Fliki or Zebrafat convert text into videos with visuals, music and pacing. AI voice tools like ElevenLabs or Murf provide human-like narration. Avatar tools like HeyGen or D-ID can even create digital presenters.

The entire process can take under 30 minutes. Cost per video can drop to a few hundred rupees. One person can run multiple channels simultaneously. Think of it less as filmmaking, and more as content manufacturing.

ADVERTISERS DITCHING HUMANS TOO

Brands are not far behind. Fashion label Mango



AN AI-GENERATED REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

launched a campaign using only AI-generated models. No shoots, no logistics and no unpredictability. Virtual influencers are available 24/7, can be placed anywhere digitally and never go off-script. Campaigns reportedly deliver up to 30 per cent higher engagement at nearly half the cost. For marketers, the math is simple.

DARK SIDE OF FACELESS EMPIRE

Rise of AI slop: Kapwing describes AI slop as content which is mass-produced, has low-value content and is built purely for clicks. Over 20 per cent of videos now fall into this category.

Misinformation at scale: AI content can spread false information rapidly, often without oversight or accountability.

Jobs on the line: As brands replace human models and creators, creative economy faces disruption.

Trust deficit: Only 23 per cent of users say they're comfortable with AI influencers. Many feel misled when they discover the "person" isn't real.

SO, IS THIS THE FUTURE?

For Ajay Yadav of *TheVibeFounder*, the answer is nuanced. "AI is a medium like a camera or a microphone. What makes content authentic is the person behind it, their knowledge, their experience and their intent," he says. "AI actually opens the door for more people to share what they know. Not everyone is comfortable on camera, and that shouldn't stop

someone with real expertise from reaching people." On the question of jobs, he sees evolution rather than elimination. "AI enhances productivity and gives humans more time for creative problem-solving and deeper thinking."

And regulation? "It's an evolving conversation," Yadav says. "As technology grows, policies will adapt to protect people's rights and safety. Any approach that puts humanity first is the right direction."

THE HUMAN EDGE

Even in this AI-driven world, storytelling still wins. A compelling idea, a sharp hook and a relatable insight, these are still human strengths. The most successful creators are not those who outsource everything to AI, but those who use it to amplify their voice.

THE BIGGER PICTURE

India's creator economy is projected to reach ₹82,000 crore by 2027, while the global virtual influencer market could grow to ₹3.8 lakh crore by 2030. AI is lowering barriers, opening doors and democratising creation. But it is also flooding the Internet, raising questions about trust, quality and authenticity. The invisible creator is here. It is profitable, scalable and impossible to ignore.

Whether you see it as an opportunity or overload depends on one question. If anyone can create content without a face, what will make yours worth watching?